

The Great Depression

Trace how one economic collapse sent shockwaves through four systems — political, economic, social-cultural, and geographic-environmental — and decide which change lasted longest.

? Historical challenge

The 1929 crash did more than empty bank accounts. Its shockwaves reshaped American politics, the economy, society and culture, and even the land itself. Follow the event outward through four systems, weigh who benefited and who bore the costs, and decide which change left the deepest mark.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

The Great Depression – Federal Reserve History

SECONDARY SOURCE

How bank failures and a shrinking money supply deepened the collapse.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What role did bank failures and the Federal Reserve play?
- How does this source explain the depth of the Depression?

SOURCES 2

Farm Security Administration / OWI Photographs – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Government photographs documenting Dust Bowl migrants and rural poverty.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What do the photographs show about who bore the costs?
- How do images shape the way we remember an era?

SOURCES 3

Franklin D. Roosevelt Presidential Library & Museum (National Archives)

PRIMARY SOURCE

FDR's fireside chats and New Deal records documenting the federal response.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did FDR explain his response to the public?
- Which New Deal program seems most consequential? Why?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

The Great Depression

1929–1939

The United States

Political

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

.....

SECONDARY EFFECT

.....

EVIDENCE

.....

Economic

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

.....

SECONDARY EFFECT

.....

EVIDENCE

.....

Social / cultural

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

.....

SECONDARY EFFECT

.....

EVIDENCE

.....

Geographic / environmental

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

.....

SECONDARY EFFECT

.....

EVIDENCE

.....

Who benefited?

.....

Who bore the costs?

.....

Which effect had the greatest significance? Explain with evidence.

.....

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your four pathways with a partner. Did you find the same immediate and secondary effects?
- Did you rank the same pathway as most lasting? Defend your ranking with evidence.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Which system's change lasted longest after the Great Depression? Support your ranking with specific evidence from at least two pathways and two sources.